Gmail

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Reflections from Beyond the Bend

1 message

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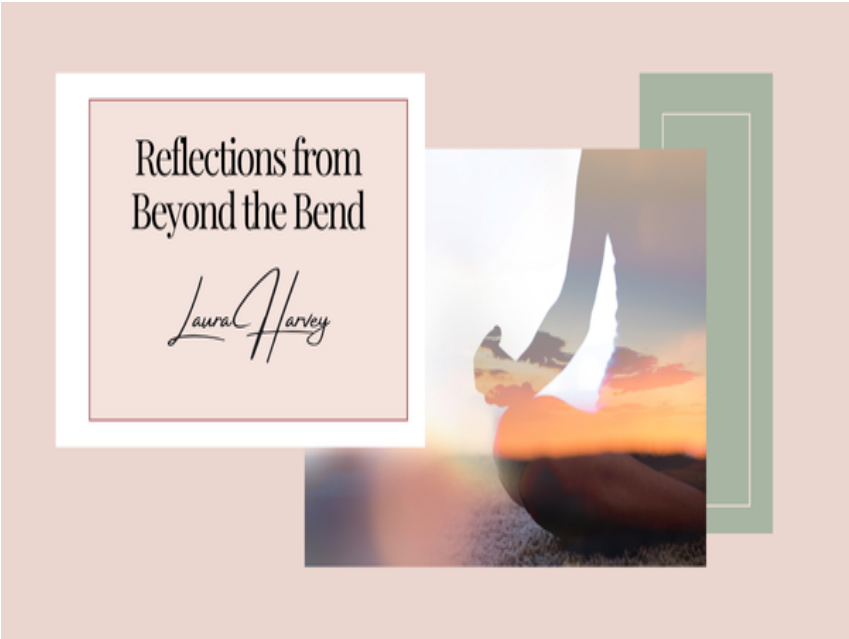
BEYOND THE BEND YOGA



Hi Laura

As I sit down to write to you this week, I've been reflecting on how often we're harder on ourselves than we need to be. It's so easy to slip into judgment, to carry the weight of "I should have known better" or "Why did I do that?" We all do it. But what if, instead of tightening around those moments, we softened? What if we gave ourselves just a little more mercy?

That's the spirit of this week's reflection - something that opened a whole new doorway for me, and I hope it offers you the same gentle space to breathe.

With warmth and gratitude,
Laura 🌿

This Week's Wellness Wisdom

A Buddhist Perspective That Made Space for Mercy

By Laura Harvey | Beyond the Bend Yoga

I was listening to an interview with Elizabeth Gilbert recently (one of my absolute heroes), and she shared something that landed so deeply with me. She spoke about a Buddhist teaching that instead of labeling things as right or wrong, we can see them as skilled or unskilled.

I love this shift in language. It takes us out of judgment and shame, and instead invites us into curiosity and growth.

In Buddhism:

A skilled (kusala) action is one that arises from clarity, compassion, or wisdom. It leads to freedom from suffering and creates conditions for peace and well-being - both for ourselves and those around us.

An unskilled (akusala) action arises from confusion, craving, fear, or anger. It adds to our suffering, clouds the mind, and often harms our relationships or deepens our own struggles.

What I love about this is that it reframes the whole picture. Instead of saying, “I’m bad because I snapped at someone,” we can say, “That was an unskilled way of handling my stress. What could be more skillful next time?”

I’ve noticed this in my own life. Sometimes I’ll say or do something that

isn’t so kind, and my old pattern would be to beat myself up about it: “Why did I do that? I’m a bad person.” But when I look through this Buddhist lens, I can soften. I can say, “That was an unskilled choice, but it doesn’t define me.” From that place, I can reflect: “If I had been in a more skillful, compassionate space, what might I have chosen differently?”

For me, this perspective feels so freeing. It allows me to be merciful with myself, to remove the harsh judgment, and to stay curious about how I want to show up next time. And it reminds me that living authentically isn’t about being perfect - it’s about gently moving toward more skillful choices, rooted in compassion for myself and for others.

And just as important, it changes how I see others. When someone else acts harshly, it doesn’t mean they’re a bad person - it simply means they’re acting from an unskilled place. That shift helps me to hold them with more mercy, too.

For me, the beauty of this perspective is the freedom it brings. When I can say, “That was unskilled” instead of “That was bad,” there’s space to breathe. Judgment loosens its grip. My heart feels lighter, more open. And in that space, I feel more alive, more free.

I invite you to play with this lens in your own life - to notice the shift that happens when you see an action, yours or someone else’s, not as wrong or bad, but simply as unskilled. See how it feels in your body, in your heart. You might find that same sense of space and freedom waiting for you, too.

✨ Upcoming Classes

If this week's reflection on mercy and skillfulness resonates with you, you might enjoy exploring these themes in community. My fall classes are all about slowing down, listening deeply, and creating space for more skillful ways of being, both on and off the mat.

🌸 Sherwood Park - Rising Moon Studio

Evening Classes (Waitlist Only)

- **Monday Evenings – Somatic Vinyasa (6:00–7:15 p.m.)**
  Next 7-week session: November 3 – December 15
- **Tuesday Evenings – Restore and Reclaim (6:00–7:15 p.m.)**
  Next 7-week session: November 4 – December 16

✨ *Evening Update:*

- The **current sessions are full**.
- Current students have until **October 15** to reclaim their spots.
- Starting **October 16**, any available spaces will be offered to the **waiting list**.

Join the Waitlist for Your Favourite Class

Rise & Restore - Rising Moon Studio (Open Registration)

- **Tuesday Mornings – Rise and Restore (10:00–11:15 a.m.)**
  October 14 – December 16 (10-week series)
  $20 drop-in, or $170 for the full session (only $17 per class).
  A restorative yoga class to release tension, deeply rest, and bring your nervous system back into balance.

🌿 Edmonton - Center for Spiritual Living

- **Morning Stillness Yoga (Wednesday mornings, 10:00–11:15 a.m.)**
  October 29 – December 17 (8-week series)
  $20 drop-in, or $136 for the full session (only $17 per class).
  Gentle Hatha-based yoga to begin your day with clarity, ease, and

calm presence.

📍 *All classes run until mid-December.*
🧘 *Please bring a yoga mat and water bottle. A blanket is optional (I have extras in Sherwood Park if you'd like one). Blocks are provided at both locations.*

Register Now for your Favourite Morning Class

And because practice is at the heart of everything, here's one to carry with you this week…

🌿 Practice of the Week: From Pause to Mercy

One of the most powerful ways to live into this idea of “skilled vs. unskilled” is to bring it into our everyday moments and then give ourselves space to reflect with compassion. This practice blends both: a pause you can take in real time, and a meditation you can return to later. Together, they create a cycle of awareness, mercy, and growth.

The Skilled Response Pause (in the moment)

The next time irritation, defensiveness, or self-criticism arises, try this:

1. **Notice the spark.** Catch the moment before you react.
2. **Anchor in the body.** Place a hand on your heart or belly. Take three slow breaths.
3. **Name it gently.** Silently say: *“This is an unskilled impulse.”*
4. **Open to possibility.** Ask: *“What would be a more skillful response here?”*
5. **Choose one shift.** Maybe it’s softening your tone, stepping away, or offering yourself a kind word.

Even if you don’t always succeed in shifting, the act of pausing plants the seed of awareness.

Compassionate Reframing Meditation (later, in quiet)

At the end of the day, or anytime you want to reset, find a quiet place to sit for 10–15 minutes.

1. Close your eyes and take a few grounding breaths.
2. Recall one of the moments from your day when you paused - or when you wished you had.
3. Instead of judgment, say silently: *“That was unskilled, not unworthy.”*
4. With each breath, offer yourself compassion:
    - Inhale: *“I am learning.”*
    - Exhale: *“I choose compassion.”*
5. Imagine how you might respond more skillfully next time. See it.

5. Imagine how you might respond more skillfully next time. See it, feel it, and let your body register the possibility.
6. Close with a blessing: *“May I grow in skill. May I act with clarity and compassion - for myself and others.”*

Why it matters

By weaving the pause into your day and the meditation into your evening, you create a gentle rhythm of awareness and reflection. Over time, the line between the two blurs - your pauses become more compassionate, and your meditations begin to shape your daily choices.

It’s not about perfection. It’s about building a life where skill, mercy, and compassion slowly become your natural way of being.

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